

Cognitive Distortions Reference

Greater Nashua Mental Health Center

Cognitive distortions are habitual patterns of biased thinking that can maintain negative emotions. Learning to recognize them is the first step toward challenging and reframing unhelpful thoughts.

1. All-or-Nothing Thinking

Seeing things in black-or-white categories with no middle ground.

Example: "I didn't finish the whole project, so it's a total failure."

2. Overgeneralization

Drawing broad conclusions from a single event, using words like 'always' or 'never.'

Example: "I got rejected once. I'll never find a relationship."

3. Mental Filter

Focusing exclusively on one negative detail while ignoring the bigger picture.

Example: "My boss praised my work but mentioned one typo — the whole report must be terrible."

4. Disqualifying the Positive

Dismissing positive experiences as not counting or being irrelevant.

Example: "They only said that to be nice. They didn't really mean it."

5. Mind Reading

Assuming you know what others are thinking without evidence.

Example: "Everyone at the meeting thought my idea was stupid."

6. Fortune Telling

Predicting negative outcomes without evidence and treating them as established facts.

Example: "I know the interview will go badly. There's no point in preparing."

7. Magnification / Minimization

Blowing things out of proportion or shrinking their importance inappropriately.

Example: "My small mistake is a disaster, but my promotion is no big deal."

8. Emotional Reasoning

Assuming that your feelings reflect reality: 'I feel it, so it must be true.'

Example: "I feel anxious about flying, so planes must be dangerous."

9. Should Statements

Using 'should,' 'must,' or 'ought to' statements that create unrealistic expectations.

Example: "I should always be productive. I must never make mistakes."

10. Labeling

Attaching a fixed, global label to yourself or others instead of describing the behavior.

Example: "I made an error, so I'm a complete idiot."

11. Personalization

Blaming yourself for events outside your control, or taking things too personally.

Example: "My child got a bad grade — I must be a terrible parent."

12. Catastrophizing

Expecting the worst-case scenario and believing you cannot cope with it.

Example: "If I fail this test, my life is over."

13. Blame

Holding others entirely responsible for your emotional pain, or vice versa.

Example: "It's all their fault I feel this way. They ruined everything."

14. Always Being Right

Prioritizing being right over the feelings of others; treating opinions as facts.

Example: "I don't care how they feel — I know I'm correct and I'll prove it."

15. Fallacy of Change

Believing that others should change to suit your needs and that happiness depends on them changing.

Example: "If only my partner would change, I'd finally be happy."

My most common distortions: (list the ones you notice most often)

